> "THE ENGLISH REMAINED QUITE SILENT WITH SHOULDERED ARMS, AND FROM THEIR STEADINESS THEY APPEARED TO BE A LONG RED WALL ... THEY BEGAN TO FIRE. THE ENEMY'S STEADY, CONCENTRATED VOLLEYS SWEPT OUR RANKS."
>
> **THOMAS BOUGEAUD**, FRENCH INFANTRY OFFICER IN THE PENINSULAR WAR

faced the hazardous prospect of fighting their way through the heavily defended opening. The assault on the breach was headed by a junior officer who led a group of volunteers known by long tradition as the Forlorn Hope. Instead of it being difficult to find volunteers for this exceptionally dangerous mission, there was keen competition to take part, especially among officers who could hope for a promotion if they survived.

The assault took place under cover of darkness, but the Forlorn Hope was inevitably under heavy fire by the time the party rushed the rubble-filled breach, which had often been booby-trapped by French engineers. One Forlorn Hope during the siege of Badajoz lost some 180 of its 200 men. The assault parties following behind, some carrying ladders, could also expect substantial losses, advancing over the bodies of the fallen. The existing rules of war were that if a fortress failed to surrender once its walls were breached, the attackers had the right to pillage the place once taken. At Ciudad Rodrigo, Badajoz, and San Sebastian, Wellington's soldiers indulged this right to the full. Civilians were the victims of an orgy of murder, rape, and robbery as British soldiers took their revenge for the risks and hardships of the campaign.

ON THE FIELD OF BATTLE

When facing the French in open battle, the British infantry were radically different creatures from the drunken rabble that sacked Badajoz. Their most striking characteristic was "steadiness", a quality especially admired by those who had experienced at first hand the sheer terror of the Napoleonic battlefield. Unarmoured men had to stand firm in the face of cannon fire, muskets, bayonets, lances, and sabres. Casualties were inevitably high. When British infantry faced a French onslaught at Albuera in 1811, around two-thirds of their men were killed or wounded, and yet they held the field. A soldier wrote proudly that "men were knocked about like skittles, but not a step backwards was taken".

During the Peninsular campaigns, Wellington began by exploiting the ability of his troops to hold a defensive position, in particular occupying the lines of Torres Vedras outside Lisbon in 1810–11. But later his army, with its Portuguese and Spanish allies, had opportunities to show true offensive spirit, especially at the battle of Salamanca in 1812. In this notable engagement, British infantry boldly marched forward in columns and then deployed in line – a textbook manoeuvre – to attack French forces that had allowed themselves to become overextended.



Waterloo medal
Awarded to soldiers present at the battles of Ligny, Quatre Bras, and Waterloo, this was the first medal to be given to all ranks. Veterans were also credited with two years' extra service.



Infantry squares
French cuirassiers charge the 42nd Highlanders at Waterloo in 1815. Drawn up in square formation, infantry battalions were almost impervious to attack by cavalry, who were unable to penetrate the massed ranks of men and bayonets.